

8-BALL SCENE

We open through the lens of a scope. In its center, a bright red dot trails a creased leather crown atop a chocolate colored brim. From our vantage point the quarry can not be clearly seen, only their brown hat weaving through a sea of other hats and hair directly below — or maybe it's above? Here in a city sprawling across the inner walls of a hollow sphere, with the beating heat of the Sunlock at its core, one's sense of up and down is rendered rather meaningless.

A freight car passes between the reticle and the hat of interest through the mega city's unified "skyline", blocking our view. As the car passes we find our view has now changed, no longer a seemingly bird's eye perspective, and free of the crosshairs. We're now at ground level on the other side of the city, and across a crowded street we catch a glimpse of that leather curved brim ducking beneath an awning, and crossing through a knot of pedestrians waiting beside a transit stop, before ducking away into an alleyway away from the crowd.

Our view shifts to the alleyway, dark and musty from the pooled condensation from nearby cooling units. The silhouette of an android can be seen framed in hazy neon red light beneath the shade of an exposed ventilation duct. Without the assistance of low-light vision all we can make out of the figure is the faint glow of their optic eyes, two golden discs peering from the shadows at the approach of the mysterious leather crown and curved brim hat. In this moment we finally get a decent glance at the hat's owner; a worn duster of the same material and color shroud glimpses of metallic sheen from underneath. Like with the dark silhouette we can see from beneath the chocolate brim of the lone stranger the light of two optic eyes, now meeting the golden gaze of the shadows. For several moments neither figure speaks; the sound of a distant hydraulic lift groaning from somewhere beyond the alley.

The silhouette gestures at the lone stranger's attire.

"Not very subtle."

"I wasn't going for subtle."

"You're the contact?"

"That depends. Do you have something for me?"

We watch as the golden eyed android takes a step out of the shadows into the dim light. His clothes, in stark contrast to the lone stranger's, look common and plain. Dark trousers, a weathered coat, and a narrow satchel, all a dull grey that could easily vanish among the local residents of Kharosai effortlessly. The lone stranger looks on silently as the droid reaches beneath his coat and produces a small metallic disk between his fingers. Even in the bad light we can just about make out its pale face surrounded by a darker rim, broken only by a shallow pattern pressed artisanally into the surface.

Turning back to the lone stranger, we see the apertures of his eyes narrow, focusing on the disk.

Several more moments pass. Then, the lone stranger turns his head, glancing back towards the mouth of the alley, before quietly regarding the golden eyed courier once more.

“That’ll do.”

We catch a glimpse of the courier sliding the strange disk back into his coat.

“Lead the way.”

Our view pulls slightly back as we trail the two androids as they discretely make their way through the streets of one of Kharosai's many industrial districts. We follow as they descend a narrow stairwell beneath a row of residential units, pass through a service market crowded with replacement filters and secondhand machine parts, before emerging onto a suspended walkway. The warm light of the Sunlock catches the edges of passing workers, casting sharp moving shadows along the walkway. We see as a municipal drone drops from an overhead rail, then bathes the pair in the pale blue light of a scanner pass, before continuing on its route without comment.

The droids eventually leave the heavier foot traffic behind as they enter the older part of the district. The buildings here are broader — built more for freight than people — their exterior walls interrupted by loading doors, service ladders, and pipes painted over so many times the warning labels underneath have become raised shapes. Finally, we watch as the lone stranger stops before an unmarked recessed metal door. He looks carefully up and down the way for any signs of prying eyes, before turning back to the door; pressing two fingers against the release. The courier watches on as nothing happens. The lone stranger waits, then presses again, and somewhere inside we hear a lock disengage.

The courier looks towards the door, then at him.

“Packing heat?”

“Always.”

The lone stranger pushes open the door, and he and the courier step into the space beyond.

Seeing inside, we take in what appears to be an old transfer room. Most of the original equipment can be seen still bolted in place. A loading frame hangs motionless from the ceiling, several cargo restraints sit folded into the floor, and a battered worktable has been pulled beneath the only functioning overhead light.

Standing behind the table, the imposing form of a barrel-chested vesk can now be seen. The bluesish scales of its reptilian face reflect iridescently in the pale light, except for a thin orange scar that crosses the vesk's left eye.

The unlit portions of the room beyond the table are shrouded in pools of darkness, which comes flooding to quench the light from outside as the lone stranger closes the door behind him.

The vesk's good eye looks towards the lone stranger entering into the light, drifting to the courier as he steps up beside him, then back to the stranger.

"You're late."

"I'm cautious."

"Were you followed?"

"Like I said, I'm cautious."

A hissy sigh escapes through the vesk's toothy maw. Its eye once again shifting to the courier.

"Show it to me."

We see the courier steal a glance at the lone stranger, who nods approvingly, before the courier begins reaching beneath his coat...

The lights suddenly cut out as a violent electrical crack fills the room.

Our view tears sideways into white static. We hear something thud against the floor as the flashes of gunshots fill the room. For several terrible seconds we barely make out brief impressions of movement between muzzle flashes. This is followed by the sound of another thud, and then nothing but silence and darkness.

Seconds or minutes pass, then our vision is flooded with white amidst the sound of popping joints and crunching bones.

We blink. We're seeing from the eyes of the lone stranger.

The picture is pixelated and distorted at first, but slowly the room comes back into view. From the angle of the vision we can determine that the lone stranger is lying on his side. Another blink. We can now see that either the lights have returned, or the lone stranger's optics can see in the dark. Across the floor only a few feet away is the now dark optics of the courier, facing us in an empty stare. Smoke slowly rises from the singed remains of his face.

The sound of footsteps approach from off-screen, and the lone stranger turns to see not the vesk, but instead a smaller and more feminine figure walk over to the courier's body. She is wearing some sort of form fitting polymer weave, and a featureless faceplate obscuring her face. The lone stranger watches on as his diagnostic module flashes into view indicating several points of severe damage, as the woman kneels beside the courier. She reaches beneath his coat, searches once, then reaches farther beneath the fabric. Her hand emerges holding the small metallic disk.

As she brings up her hand up to the overhead light, turning the disk as though checking something on its surface, we can see that her uncovered fingers are burned. The flesh at her fingertips reddened like gums, blistered, the skin cracking apart. Inflamed veins can be seen scratching down her fingers and across her hands.

She closes her rotted fingers around the disc.

We hear the scraping sound of metal on metal as our vision begins to rise, and the lone stranger tries to force himself upright.

“Annabelle.”

She turns towards us, the cold polymer shell of her featureless mask staring down at us. From this angle, we notice a sharp tear in her side that left a jagged shred in the polymer weave. Within the shred we can see similarly inflamed veins stretching out from a splotch of orange, rubbery, skin, covered in tiny lilac growths that would give the skin a braille-like texture.

“I told you nothing good would come of this.”

Our vision turns as the lone stranger notices his rotating pistol only a few feet away where it fell during the fire fight. With a lurch we watch as the stranger dives for his weapon, as a clap of thunder fills the room. As our vision clears, the diagnostic module flashes up again, but we can already see the damage as the stranger stares at the stump. The stranger catches himself against the floor and turning back to Annabelle, who now held a scoped rifle pointing directly at his head.

“What did you do?”

“You had your warning.”

We and the lone stranger stare down the rifle's barrel for several moments, knowing any second could be our last.

“You knew I'd come.”

“I thought you might.”

“Then why warn me?”

Annabelle glances back toward the courier, then back down her scope at us.

“I hoped I was wrong.”

For a precious moment, the world stops.

Then it ends.

BOOM